Phonological Realisations of Schwa Sound by Yoruba-English Bilingual University Students

Olusoga Oludotun Ayinde
McPherson University, Seriki Sotayo

Abstract
Previous research on English as a Second Language (ESL) in Nigeria has predominantly focused on suprasegmental features, under the assumption that segmental features pose fewer challenges for Nigerian users of English. However, central vowels, particularly the schwa (/ə/), have been identified as problematic for many learners and users, leading to varied realisations among Nigerian speakers of English. This study, therefore, investigates the realisation of the schwa by students of the Department of English at Tai Solarin University of Education (TSU) and McPherson University (McU). The study adopts Generative Phonology as its theoretical framework. Data consists of thirty words purposively selected from Jowitt and Cruttenden. These words were read in isolation by 100 participants (70 from TSU and 30 from McU). The data were analysed using both perceptual and acoustic methods, supported by basic statistical tools such as frequency counts, percentages, and bar charts. Findings from both methods of analysis reveal that all participants from both TSU and McU substituted the schwa with other more familiar vowels ([ɔ], [a]) found in their native languages. Furthermore, the study established that this substitution was largely spelling-induced, resulting in a consistent pattern that merits phonological documentation within the context of Nigerian English usage.
Key words: Phonological realisation, schwa, central vowels, spelling-induced substitution, Nigerian English

Introduction
The English language, which is Nigeria's official language, has gone through various stages before its implantation in Nigeria. Three major factors responsible for its establishment and its continued promotion in the country are slavery, Christian missionary movement and colonization (Adetugbo, 1978; Jowitt, 1991; Danladi, 2013). With its long history in Nigeria and many functions it serves, such as the language of law and legal drafting, mass media, bureaucracy, educational instruction, among many others, English is no longer considered a foreign language in Nigeria. As stipulated in the Nigerian Education Language Policy (2004), the English language is the only language of instructions in schools, especially at the primary, secondary, and tertiary levels.

The multi-lingual and ethnic peculiarity of Nigeria, with more than 200 ethnic groups, is another factor that gives English a distinct status as a unifying language among over 500 indigenous languages (Bamgbade, 2012; Danladi, 2013; Olorunsogo, 2019). Danladi (2013) maintains strongly that no indigenous language can fulfill the roles that the English language plays in Nigeria's sociolinguistic setting. It is on this premise that it is unarguably established that the language has been embraced, adapted, and integrated into the socio-cultural fabric of the country (Adegbija, 2004; Adegbite, 1991). This interaction of English with the indigenous languages in Nigeria has given birth to a variety of English distinct from Standard British English at the morphological, syntactic,

discourse and phonological levels. It is not out of place to state that the distinctiveness of Nigerian English from Standard British English is more noticeable at the phonological level (Ayinde, 2023; Uchegbu-Ekweme & Chika, 2023).

Earlier scholarly attempts in describing the uniqueness of the Nigerian English variety ranging from Brosnahan (1958) through Banjo (1978, 2014), Bamgbose (1979, 2014) to Jowitt (1991) which are from the sociolinguistic approach, are largely based on assumptions and observations, rather than empirical investigations. Another hasty generalization is that segmental features constitute the least pronunciation and communicative challenge for Nigerian users of English. Although there seems to be no more contention on the existence of Nigerian variety of English, the international intelligibility of Nigerian English remains a question of research for linguists (Akinjobi, 2006). In a bid to address this problem, Received Pronunciation (RP) which is usually taken to be a form of Standard British English serves as a pronunciation model for non-native speakers of English. Interestingly, the same RP is the model approved to be used in Nigerian schools, colleges and universities. However, RP only exists as an ideal target, far from the common practice by most Nigerian users and learners of English, including teachers of English. (Udofot, 1997; Akinjobi, 2006, 20; Ilolo, 2013).

At the segmental level, vowels, particularly central vowels, pose a huge challenge to non-native learners and users of English, unlike consonants where places of articulation in the vocal tract aid the pronunciation. The problem becomes compounded as many English sounds, especially central vowels, are not available in almost all the Nigerian indigenous languages (Banjo, 2014; Bamgbose, 2014). This study maintains that, out of the three English central vowels, the schwa constitutes the greatest difficulty due to several reasons. It is the most frequently used vowel in English, as almost every other vowel has the tendency to be reduced to schwa, especially in unstressed positions (Roach, 2004; Cruttenden, 2008; Hudson, 2012). Also, the schwa assumes different positions, making it to be either elided or weakened significantly (Yule, 2006; Ayinde, 2014). All these features make the English schwa complex for non-native speakers and learners of English, especially Nigerians, who substitute the schwa with other more familiar vowels ([ɔ], [a]) found in their native languages. This study maintains that the substitution, largely spelling-induced, forms consistent phonological patterns which remain understudied in Nigerian English phonology.

However, there are certain supposed models of Standard English pronunciation in Nigeria. These include language professionals, such as newscasters, journalists, English Language teachers and lecturers, including students of English (Akinjobi, 2011; Akinjobi and Aina, 2014; Ayinde, 2021). Students of English at the university level were chosen for this study because they are under training in spoken English and other aspects of English phonetics, where they are exposed to Standard British English pronunciation. Given this level of training, expectations that such students who are teachers-of-English-in-training would have adequate mastery of English pronunciation, are high. It is against this background that this study has selected students of English from a public university (Tai Solarin, TSU) and a private university (McPherson, McU). The data comprising thirty words, derived from Jowitt and Cruttenden, were purposively selected and read in isolation by 100 participants, 70 from TSU and 30 from McU. The salient questions this study is curious to address are: what are the phonological realisations of English schwa

among the selected students? How do such realisations form phonological patterns? What implications would such patterns have on phonological studies in Nigeria and Nigerian English scholarship?

The English Language in Nigeria

The use of English in Nigeria is as old as the history of Nigeria as a nation itself. This assertion underscores the reason why English may not be regarded as a foreign language in the country. Nevertheless, the exact date of its first use or its first speaker is not certain. According to Adetugbo (1984), Portuguese was the first European language earlier identified in Nigeria before the contact with the British, such that a certain Oba in Benin was reported to have spoken Portuguese. In the ancient Benin kingdom, Portuguese was the language of commerce and diplomacy due to economic interest of the Benin people. The first contact with the British is said to be in Southern Nigeria some period before the Atlantic slave trade. By 1553, English men had started paying frequent visits to the Nigerian shores, especially the ports of ancient Benin and old Calabar (Adetugbo, 1984). The interaction between the British and the Nigerians resulted in a hybrid variety called pidgin, which was a simplified medium of communication involving English blended with some lexical items of the local language.

Through slave trade, missionary activities and colonisation, the English language has come to stay in Nigeria. Due to its growth, development and diverse functions in almost every sphere of life in Nigeria over the years, Adegbija (2004), Akindele and Adegbite (2005) affirm that the English language has now become nativised, acculturated and indigenised to suit the sociolinguistic milieu of the people. According to Bamgbose (1995), to make the English language a medium of day-to-day communication in Nigeria, the distinctively Nigerian usages need to be reflected in the phonological, syntactic and semantic patterns. He also emphasises the need for the speakers to reflect the evolution of distinctive Nigerian usages, attitudes and pragmatic features of the language. Ogunwale (2013), however, reiterates that, due to the forces of natural tendencies, Bamgbose (1995)'s proposal has not been totally achieved. What then constitutes such forces of natural tendencies is vague, or rather not elucidated by Ogunwale (2013).

Without any dispute, the English language has been nativized or domesticated to suit our socio-cultural context and is made to perform several functions. It is a language of educational instruction in Nigerian schools and, at the same time, the language of educational evaluation in such schools. This has been given backing by the Nigerian Education Policy (1977) which makes it mandatory for the English language to be the only language of instruction in schools, especially at the secondary and tertiary levels. English also functions as language of the government, commerce and industry, international communication and diplomacy. Additionally, English is extensively used in the Nigerian media, both print and electronic. In courts oaths are sworn to in English, as well as affidavit in support of claims and lost documents, thus making English the language of law and legal drafting in Nigeria (Ogunwale, 2013; Danladi, 2013; Foyewa, 2015).

Nigerian English

There is no gainsaying the fact that the English language is taking over the world and has become a global language as it is now used as a first, second and foreign language in many

countries. It is now a world language performing different functions: language of politics, language of administration, language of administration, language of international relations, language of technology, language of internet, and so on (Graddol, 1996; Musa, 2010; Danladi, 2013).

Furthermore, the development of the world Englishes has given birth to Indian English, South African English, Ghanaian English, among others (Kachru, 1985). In spite of the controversy over the existence of Nigerian English, there seems to be a consensus among linguists on the variations noticeable in the use of English in Nigeria. Such variations have carved a niche for Nigerian English which is notably different from SBE. Despite several attempts made by scholars to describe the variations, the codification is still a myth, far from reality. To achieve such codification, there is the need for more rigorous scholarly works on the distinctive features of Nigerian English, especially at the phonological level. This is because Nigerian English is significantly different from SBE at the phonological levels, including segmentals and prosody (Jowitt 1991; Akindele and Adegbite, 1992; Kujore, 1992, Akinjobi, 2002).

Although there seems to be a general assumption in Nigerian English phonology that segmental features constitute less difficulty for Nigerian users of English (Akinjobi, 2004; Akindele, Ayinde, 2021), this study contends the necessity for more empirical research to establish such a claim. In addition, there is also a need for more description of segmental variation in NE which results from different phonological realisations of certain difficult sounds, especially central vowels. Unlike consonants whose production is aided by certain speech organs in the vocal tract, vowels are produced with open approximation, thereby making their production complex for non-native users of English. The complexity involved in the production of vowels becomes more obvious in central vowels, especially schwa, because such vowels are not available in the phonemic inventory of almost all Nigeria's indigenous languages. The speakers rather substitute such central vowels with available ones in their indigenous languages. However, the substitution is not haphazardly carried out; it rather follows a pattern which is worthy of phonological enquiry. Therefore, this study is keen on exploring such phonological patterns with a view to examining the phonological realisations of schwa by Nigerian English users, precisely students of English from TSU and McU.

The English Central Vowels

Three central vowels exist in English and they are /ʌ, ɜ:, ə/. They are typically characterized by a neutral tongue position such that the tongue is positioned in the middle of the mouth. The production of English central vowels involves the halfway positioning of the tongue amid the front and the back of the mouth. Also, these vowels have different heights distinguishing them one from another. The position of the mouth, whether open or close, determines the heights of these vowels. They are represented with the use of the International Phonetic Alphabet (IPA). (Roach, 1997; Cruttenden, 2008). For the purpose of this study, only schwa will be discussed.

The English Schwa /ə/

This sound is commonly referred to as schwa in English phonetics. It is described as a mid-central, neutral vowel sound. It is the most frequently used vowel in English

occurring in unstressed syllables, because any reduced or unstressed vowels, including diphthongs, assume schwa in English connected speech. The segmental quality of the neighbouring sound affects the quality of the schwa. It is produced with the lip neutral and the tongue raised between mid-open and mid-close in "**a**lone, f**a**tigue, decor**a**tive, afterw**ar**d, etc.". In addition, when found adjacent to alveolar consonants [t, d, n, s, z], the schwa is produced with the tongue raised to the mid-close position in the mouth. Also, when it occurs adjacent to velar consonants [k, g], the tongue is raised slightly and retracted, as in '*long ago* [lɒŋ ə- □gəʊ] (Cruttenden, 2008). The observed contextual variability of schwa supports an alternative account of vowel reduction as the assimilation of a vowel to its surrounding segmental environment (Lindblom, 1963). In this framework, schwa is viewed as a vowel without a fixed articulatory target, assimilating to adjacent segments and thereby exhibiting substantial variation in quality.

Generative Phonology

Generative phonology is a linguistic theory within the broader framework of generative grammar, was developed by Noam Chomsky in the 1950s and 1960s. It aims to describe the mental processes underlying the production and perception of speech sounds in human languages. Generative phonology posits that speakers have underlying mental representations of sounds, called phonemes, which are abstract units that can be combined according to a set of rules to generate the actual sounds heard in speech. These rules, known as phonological rules, account for how phonemes are realized in different phonetic contexts. The theory has evolved over time and has been influential in shaping our understanding of how language is structured and processed in the mind.

Noam Chomsky and Morris Halle laid the foundation for generative phonology in their seminal work "The Sound Pattern of English" (1968). The book introduced the concept of underlying phonological representations and the use of phonological rules to derive surface forms. Generative phonology posits two levels of representation within a word: Underlying Representation (UR) and Phonetic Representation (PR). The underlying level is an abstract level representing the lexical meaning and morphological structure, often containing phonemes that may not directly correspond to surface sounds. Phonetic Representation (PR) is the actual pronunciation of the word, containing concrete phonetic features.

Underlying Representation
↓
(P-Rule)
↓
Phonetic Representation

From the schema above, there is an interface (P-Rule) between the two levels of representation in generative phonology. The P-Rule entails phonological rules, which are a set of ordered rules that apply to the UR, transforming it into the PR. These rules can involve inserting, deleting, or modifying sounds to account for sound changes, assimilation, and other phonological processes.

Generative phonology acknowledges both universal constraints on sound patterns across languages and the possibility for variation across specific languages, explained by parameter settings. Generative phonology has significantly impacted the study of sound patterns in languages, influencing various contemporary models of phonological analysis. While it has undergone further development and faced challenges from alternative frameworks, its core concepts and principles continue to play a significant role in understanding how languages shape and organize their sound systems (Goldsmith Bernard, 2012).

Methodology

70 students of English from Tai Solarin University and 30 students of English from McPherson University were purposively selected, making a total number of 100 participants. The participants from TSU outnumbers those from McU due to the large number of students in the former. TSU is a public university established by Ogun State Government, while McU is owned by Foursquare Gospel Church. The universities are both located in Ogun State, Nigeria. 30 words sourced from Jowitt's *Nigerian English usage* and Cruttenden's *Gimson's pronunciation of English* constitute the data for this study. The words selected include *husband, cucumber, urban, expert, thunder, character, allow, mother, sitter, honor*. According to Jowitt (1991), words containing schwa sound constitute the greatest challenge for most Nigerian speakers of English. These words were administered to the participants in a noise-controlled environment. The recording of the tested words pronounced in isolation by the participants was carried out using praat, a software package for sound synthesis and analysis developed by Paul Boersma and David Weenink at the Department of English Phonetics, University of Amsterdam.

Observational design which involves collection of natural data without manipulation was used for this study. The design allows the phonologist to observe phonetic and phonological variations in real-world contexts. It was adopted because it allows the researcher to study speech/sound patterns and the differences across age-groups, social contexts and regions. For the analysis, Daniel Jones' Pronouncing Dictionary served as the native baseline (SBE) with which the productions of the selected words by the participants were compared. The data were subjected to perceptual and acoustic analyses, complemented by simple statistical measures, such as frequency count, simple percentage and bar chart.

Data Analysis and Discussion of Findings

Table 1: Phonological realisations of the Schwa

S/N	Word	Native Baseline	Actual Production Dominant (TSU)	Actual Production Dominant (McU)
1	thund**er**	/`θʌn.də/	[`tonda]	[`tonda]
2	ch**a**ract**er**	/`kær.ək.tər/	[ka`rakta],	[`karakta]
3	**A**llow	/ə.`laʊ/	[ɑlau]	[ɑlau]
4	moth**er**	/`mʌð.ər/	[mɔda]	[mɔda]
5.	journ**a**l	/`dʒɜːnəl/	[dʒɔna]	[dʒɔna]
6.	hon**our**	/`ɒn.ə/	[hɔnɔ]	[ɔnɔ]
7.	husb**a**nd	/`hʌz.bənd/	[hɔsband]	[hɔzband]
8.	Anth**e**m	/`ænθəm/	[antem]	[antem]
9.	nec**e**ss**a**ry	/`nesəsəri/	[nesesri]	[nesesri]
10.	**A**ttend	/ə`tend/	[a`tend]	[atend]

The table above shows the phonological realisations of the schwa dominant in the actual production of the sampled words by the participants from TSU and McU. The native baseline production was derived from Daniel Jone's Pronouncing Dictionary. The stroke (`) is used to indicate the stressed syllable. The letter(s) representing the schwa is/are written in bold form for easy identification. While two instances of the schwa sound occur in *char**a**ct**er*** and nec**e**ss**a**ry, others (thund**er, a**llow, moth**er**, journ**a**l, hon**our**, husb**a**nd, Anth**e**m and **A**ttend) have only one. The actual productions realized by the TSU and McU participants are largely similar, as both of them produced strong vowels instead of the schwa. However, the realisations follow clear phonological patterns which forms the preoccupation of this scholarly study. Such patterns are influenced by the letter(s) representing the schwa in a particular phonological environment.

Letter-induced Substitution

According to Cruttenden 2007, the schwa is represented with different letters which have no influence on its phonological realization in SBE, even though neighbouring sounds, as discussed earlier, greatly do. In SBE, the schwa is the most frequently used vowel because every other vowel occurring in unstressed syllables has the tendency to be weakened to schwa. The knowledge of the environment to weaken vowels can be said to be purely intuitive, which a second language learner often find difficult. Educated Nigerian English which is a variety of Nigerian English used mostly by university graduates and professionals is also characterized with spelling-induced pronunciation in regards to the schwa. Being university students, the participants for this study can also be grouped into the category of Educated Nigerian English users, following Banjo's (1978) classification of the Nigerian English variety. As students of English, expectation is usually high upon their graduation from the university since they must have undergone training in spoken English and phonology.

In NE, the schwa is represented with different letters which greatly impact on its phonological realisations in various words. From the words used for this study, schwa represented by letter "a" was frequently realized by both TSU and McU participants as the strong vowel /a/. Words in this category include *char**a**cter, **a**llow, **a**ttend,* husb**a**nd, journ**a**l. 97.1% (68 out of 70) of TSU participants substituted with /a/ against 90% (27 out of 30) of the McU participants. Even though McU students produced the sound slightly better than their TSU counterparts, the realisations were not significant. The only exception recorded was in the production of the schwa represented by "a" in the word *necess**a**ry*, where the majority of the participants from both McU and TSU elided the schwa. Elision of the schwa in such an environment has formed a phonological pattern in Educated NE, as realised in the pronunciation of certain words such as *advers**a**ry, emiss**a**ry, anniver**a**ry*. The statistical distribution of the schwa substituted by letter "a" and realized as vowel /a/ by both TSU and McU participants are represented in the bar chart below.

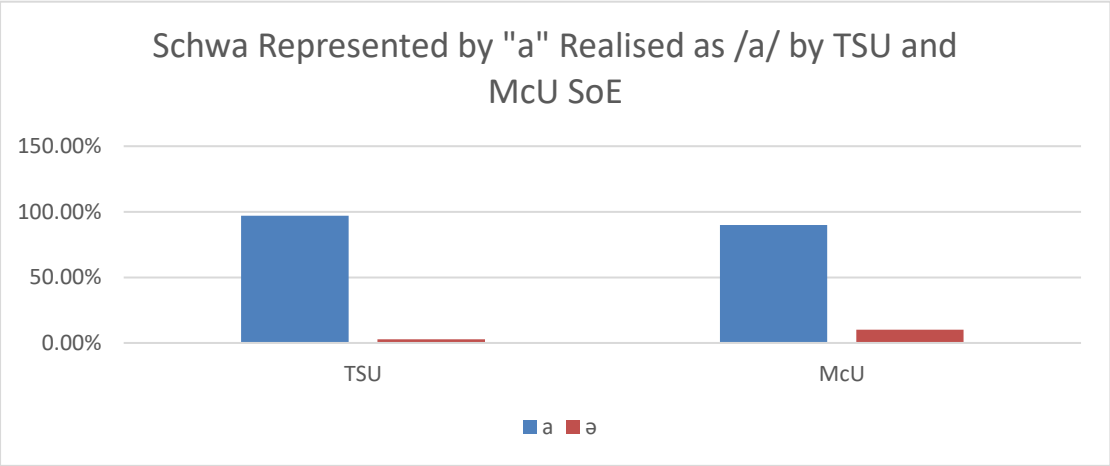

Fig.1: Letter a Schwa Realised as /a/ by TSU and McU SoE

Another level of realization of the schwa sound is induced by "er". In Standard British English, these letters are frequently realized as /ɜ:/, especially when found in stressed syllables, as in *terminal, germinate, fern*; whereas they are more frequently rendered weak and realized as schwa in unstressed syllables, as in *teacher, burner, runner*. This study reveals that majority of the participants both from TSU and McU realized the shwa strong where the sound is represented by "er". This realization also formed a phonological pattern in spoken educated Nigerian English. For instance, "er" occurring at the word-final boundary in unstressed syllables, as in *character*, *teacher*, *miner*, is more frequently realized as /a/ in spoken Educated NE. Whereas "er" occurring at the word-initial boundary preceding a consonant in unstressed syllables, as in *perceive*, *persist*, *pertain* are either realized as /a/ or /e/. The statistical distribution of the schwa represented by "er" at the word-final boundary realized as vowel /a/ by both TSU and McU participants are represented in the bar chart below:

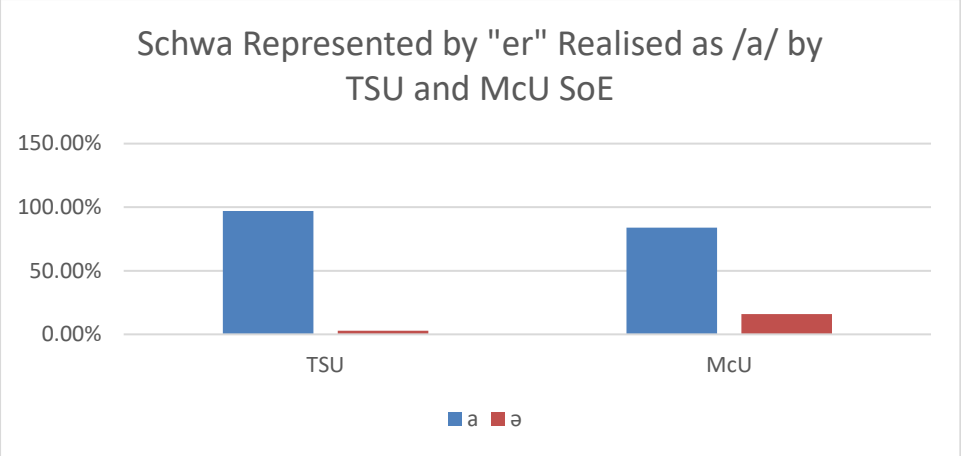

Fig.2: Letters "er" **Schwa Realised as /a/ by TSU and McU SoE**

The bar chart distribution shows that the realisations of er-schwa at the word-initial boundary by students of English (SoE) vary. Only 2 out of 70 TSU participants approximated to the RP schwa. By implication, more than 97% of the TSU participants realized schwa as /a/. Even though McU students of English performed better than their TSU counterparts, the difference is not significant. 5 out of 30 McU participants produced the schwa sound close to the RP, implying that about 84% of their population still realized the er-schwa at the word-final boundary strong and produced it as /a/.

Another digraph which often represents the schwa vowel in SBE is "or". In SBE, "or/our" occurring in stressed syllables are either realized strong as /ɔ:/, as in *corps, port* and *sort*, or /ɜ:/ as in *work*, *world and worth*. However, "or/our" found in unstressed syllables, as in *doctor*, *rector* and *labour*, is realized as schwa in SBE. Most learners of English in the second language setting have difficulty with this inconsistent nature of English pronunciation. The only word in this regard is *honour*. All the participants from TSU realized the 'our' in *honour* strong /ɔ:/, against what the schwa realization in SBE. Thus, 100% of TSU participants did not realise the 'our' in *honour* as schwa. Only 1 out of the 30 McU participants approximated to the Standard British English *our*-schwa. By implication, almost 97% of the McU participants failed to approximate to Standard British English pronunciation in respect to the production of "or/our" in unstressed positions. Below is the bar chart representation of the *our*-schwa by both TSU and McU students of English.

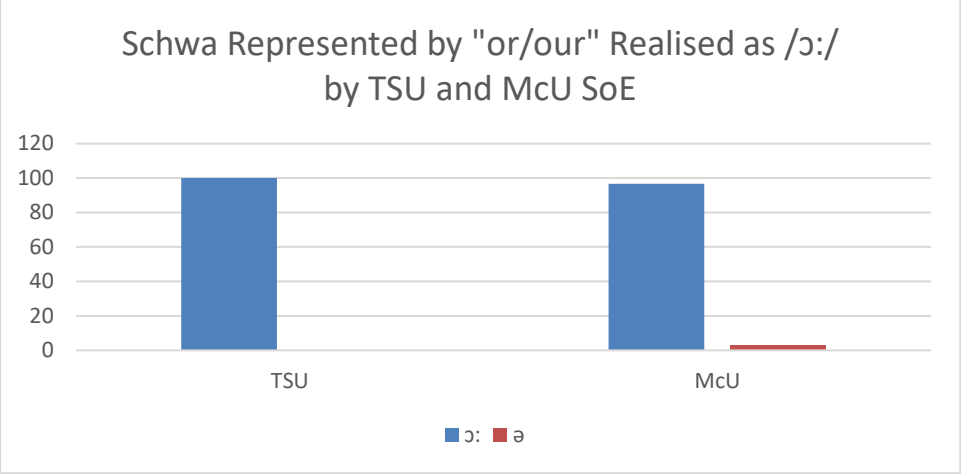

Fig.3: Realisation of "or" Schwa as /ɔ:/ by TSU and McU SoE

The bar chart above shows the realization of the or/our-induced schwa by TSU and McU students of English. It is evident in the chart that the schwa is a complex vowel for the participants. The TSU participants completely replaced the schwa with strong vowel /ɔ:/, while only one of the 30 participants from McU approximated to the Standard British English schwa represented by 'our'. However, this does not suffice to say that McU students had better performance than their TSU counterparts. This is because the difference cannot be said to be significant since only 1 out 30 McU participants approximated to the *our*-schwa.

Another letter which also represents Standard British English schwa is 'e' in unstressed syllables. It is also another letter representing schwa which most Nigerian users of English frequently find difficult in terms of pronunciation. Words in this category include *anth**e**m*, *brethr**e**n*, *embl**e**m*, *mill**e**t*. All the participants from both TSU and McU performed woefully in the pronunciation of *e*-schwa as they all ended up producing the strong vowel /e/. Usually in SBE, letter 'e' found in stressed syllables are more frequently realized strong as /e/, as in ***e**ffort*, *f**e**llow*, *k**e**ttle*, *n**e**cessary*. The bar chart representation for the production of e-schwa by both TSU and McU participants is given below:

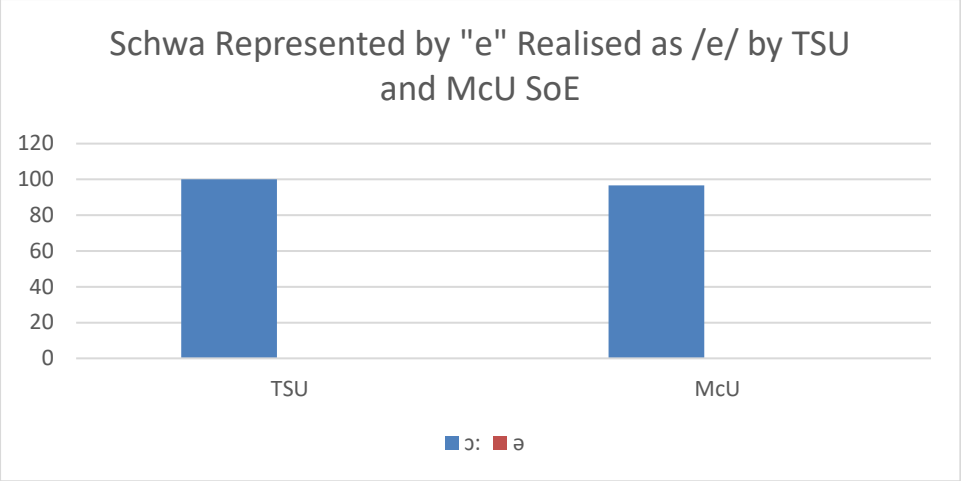

Fig.4: Realisation of "or" Schwa as /ɔ:/ by TSU and McU SoE

The bar chart above shows the realisations of or-schwa by TSU and McU students of English. The result shows that the participants in their entirety realized the schwa as /ɔ:/. This shows that the participants realized the schwa strong like "or" in stressed syllables, as in *sort*, *port*, *sport*. The strong realization of schwa by the participants from both TSU and McU confirms earlier studies on Nigerian English, both non-empirical (Jibril, 1982; Jowitt,1991; Banjo, 2014) and empirical (Ojarikre, 2015; Akamo, 2023) that Nigerians still find the pronunciation of schwa difficult as the vowel is frequently realized strong.

Conclusion

In conclusion, the findings from the analysis provide compelling evidence that the realisation of schwa by students of English in both TSU and McU shows significant departure from Standard British English. The preference for the full vowel /a/ in contexts where schwa is expected, particularly at word-initial and word-final boundaries, reveals a deeply entrenched pattern that cuts across both groups of learners. With over 97% of TSU participants and about 84% of McU participants failing to approximate the RP schwa, it is evident that the principle of vowel reduction, which underpins the rhythm and prosody of English, remains largely uninternalised. Although McU students demonstrate a slightly higher level of approximation, the marginal difference does not translate into any substantial phonological competence.

More revealing is the near-total absence of schwa realisation in the production of the "or/our" digraph in unstressed syllables. The categorical rendering of *honour* with a strong vowel by virtually all participants underscores the extent to which orthographic influence overrides phonological conditioning in learners' speech. This suggests that the unpredictable correspondence between spelling and sound in English continues to pose a major challenge, especially in second language contexts where exposure to native-like input is limited. The learners' consistent use of strong vowels in weak positions further indicates a broader difficulty with the distinction between strong and weak forms, a feature that is central to natural, connected speech.

From a broader perspective, these results have important implications for the description of Nigerian English phonology. The systematic replacement of schwa with /a/

in unstressed syllables may be seen not merely as learner error but as an emerging, stabilised feature of Nigerian English. This aligns with the tendency in many New Englishes to reduce vowel centralisation and maintain clearer, more syllable-timed rhythmic patterns, influenced by indigenous languages. Consequently, what is traditionally viewed as deviation from Standard British English may, in fact, reflect an evolving endonormative standard within the Nigerian context.

Pedagogically, however, the findings raise critical concerns. While the recognition of Nigerian English as a legitimate variety is important, the persistent inability of learners—particularly students of English, to approximate widely accepted standard norms suggests a gap in pronunciation teaching. This has implications for intelligibility in international communication and for learners who require proficiency in exonormative standards for academic or professional purposes. Therefore, English language pedagogy in Nigeria must strike a balance between acknowledging local norms and equipping learners with the skills to navigate global standards. This can be achieved through more explicit instruction in phonetics and phonology, increased emphasis on weak forms and connected speech, and the incorporation of auditory-rich teaching methods that expose learners to diverse models of English pronunciation.

Ultimately, the patterns observed in this study underscore the need for a more nuanced approach to English language teaching, one that recognises the legitimacy of Nigerian English while also addressing areas of divergence that may hinder broader communicative effectiveness.

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